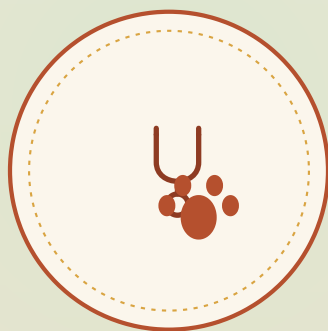




COMPANION GUIDE

Beyond the Recipes

Diagnosis, Science & Safe Recovery

For readers of *Therapeutic Diets for Dogs*





"The recipes tell you what to feed. This guide tells you why — and how to know it's working."

This companion volume was built to sit alongside *Therapeutic Diets for Dogs*. It does not repeat the 10 recipes or the Substitution Matrix — it fills in what recipes alone can't: how to recognize what you're dealing with, the science behind why these meals work, a real weight-loss protocol, and a deeper look at hidden ingredients to avoid.

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IMPORTANT NOTICE

This guide is educational and does not replace veterinary diagnosis or treatment. Any suspected food allergy, chronic digestive issue, or weight-loss plan should be supervised by a licensed veterinarian.

How to Use This Companion

If you own *Therapeutic Diets for Dogs*, you already have the meals. What you may not have yet is the full picture around them — and that gap is exactly what causes most therapeutic diets to fail.

Here's what typically happens: a tutor reads that hydrolyzed protein or a sensitive-stomach recipe helped another dog, jumps straight to cooking, and skips the part that actually determines success — confirming the problem is food in the first place, understanding why the ingredients work, tracking the response properly, and knowing when a recipe alone isn't enough.



WHAT THIS BOOK DOES DIFFERENTLY

No recipes are repeated here. Every chapter fills a gap the main guide leaves open: diagnosis, mechanism, protocol, and a deeper ingredient audit — plus three practical tools you can use immediately.

Use it in order if you're just starting: Chapter 1 helps you confirm what you're actually dealing with before you spend weeks cooking a diet that may not even address the root cause. If you're already using the recipes and want to understand *why* they work, or need the weight-protocol and ingredient-audit chapters, feel free to jump straight there.

- ✓ **Chapter 1** helps you tell food sensitivity apart from other causes, before you start cooking.
- ✓ **Chapter 2** explains the biology behind why the hypoallergenic and gut-soothing recipes work.
- ✓ **Chapter 3** turns the weight-management recipes into an actual structured protocol.
- ✓ **Chapter 4** goes past the basics and audits hidden allergens most tutors never think to check.
- ✓ **The three bonus tools** give you a decision point for the vet, a way to track progress, and a way to read any bag of food you're still using alongside the homemade meals.



Let's start where every therapeutic diet should: confirming what you're actually treating.



CHAPTER ONE

Simple Diagnosis: Is It Really Food?

Before you cook a single meal, confirm what you're actually dealing with.

- Food sensitivity vs. environmental allergy
- Skin symptoms vs. digestive symptoms
- How an elimination diet trial actually works
- A quick self-assessment

CHAPTER 01

1.1 Food sensitivity vs. environmental allergy

The single biggest reason a therapeutic diet "doesn't work" is that food was never the actual trigger. Itching, ear infections, and digestive upset can come from at least three different roots, and only one of them responds to a diet change.

FOOD-RELATED

Reaction to a specific protein or ingredient. Symptoms are often present **year-round** and don't track with seasons.

ENVIRONMENTAL

Pollen, dust mites, mold, fleas. Symptoms are often **seasonal** or tied to a location/exposure, and paws/face are hit hardest.

Both can look identical from the outside — itchy skin, red ears, paw licking — which is exactly why the recipes in the main guide come with an important instruction most owners skip: **an elimination trial confirms the cause**, a recipe alone does not.

A USEFUL CLUE

Environmental allergies frequently show a seasonal pattern and respond partially to antihistamines. Food sensitivities usually don't improve with antihistamines and don't follow the calendar. Neither clue is definitive — only your vet and an elimination trial can confirm it.

1.2 Two symptom clusters, two starting points

The main guide is organized around this same split — Section 1 (Hypoallergenic) targets the skin cluster, Section 2 (Sensitive Stomach) targets the digestive cluster. Knowing which cluster your dog fits helps you pick the right section instead of guessing.

SKIN / ALLERGY CLUSTER

Persistent itching, hot spots, recurring ear infections, paw chewing/licking, red or greasy skin, hair loss in patches, chronic low-grade skin odor.

DIGESTIVE / SENSITIVE-STOMACH CLUSTER

Chronic or recurring diarrhea, soft stool that never fully firms up, excess gas, vomiting bile or foam, reluctance to eat, gurgling stomach sounds.

Some dogs show both clusters at once — this is common with true food allergy and doesn't mean anything went wrong with your assessment. It simply points you to combine recipes from both sections, which the main guide's recipes are built to allow.

1.3 How an elimination trial actually works

Several recipes in the main guide mention "an 8-week elimination diet trial" — here's what that means in practice, since doing it incorrectly is the most common reason tutors give up too early.

1

NOVEL

Pick one novel protein, one novel carb

Choose ingredients your dog has never eaten before (Recipe 1, 2, or 3 in the main guide). No treats, no table scraps, no flavored medication during the trial.

2

STRICT

Feed only that recipe for 8 weeks

Consistency is what makes the trial valid. A single slip (one treat, one flavored chew) can restart the clock.

3

LOG

Track symptoms weekly

Use the Symptom Diary in Bonus B. Look for a genuine trend, not day-to-day noise.

4

CONFIRM

Reintroduce, one ingredient at a time

If symptoms clear, your vet may guide a controlled reintroduction of old foods, one at a time, to identify the exact trigger.

1.4 Quick self-assessment

Answer honestly before starting a therapeutic diet. This doesn't replace a vet visit — it just helps you walk in with a clearer picture.

- ✓ Have symptoms been present for more than 4 weeks, regardless of season?
- ✓ Do symptoms fail to improve with flea prevention or antihistamines?
- ✓ Has your dog had recurring ear infections or hot spots more than twice?
- ✓ Are you able to commit to 8 strict weeks with no treats or table scraps?

Three or more "yes" answers is a strong signal that a food-based cause is worth investigating with a proper elimination trial — and that the recipes in the main guide are the right tool. Fewer than that, and it's worth ruling out fleas, environmental allergens, or another condition with your vet first, so you don't spend two months cooking for a problem the diet can't fix.



Next: the biology behind why these specific ingredients calm inflamed skin and guts.



CHAPTER TWO

The Anti-Inflammatory Science

Why these ingredients actually calm itchy skin and upset stomachs — plus 3 novel-protein toppers not found in the main guide.

- What inflammation is actually doing
- The 4 nutrients doing the real work
- 3 anti-inflammatory topper recipes

CHAPTER 02

2.1 What inflammation is actually doing

When your dog's immune system flags a protein as a threat — correctly or not — it releases inflammatory compounds meant to fight it off. That response is what shows up as itchy skin, hot spots, or an irritated gut lining. The goal of a therapeutic diet is twofold:

remove the trigger (Chapters 1 and 4), and **actively calm the response** that's already underway. This second part is where specific nutrients matter, and it's the part the recipes use without fully explaining.

♦ WHY THIS MATTERS PRACTICALLY

Removing the trigger stops new damage. Anti-inflammatory nutrients help the skin barrier and gut lining actually recover — which is why symptoms usually take weeks, not days, to fully resolve even on the right diet.

2.2 The four nutrients doing the real work

OMEGA-3 FATTY ACIDS (EPA/DHA)

Found in the fish oil used across nearly every recipe in the main guide. Omega-3s are converted into compounds that actively dial down inflammatory signaling — this is the single most-supported ingredient for both itchy skin and gut inflammation in dogs.

QUERCETIN (BLUEBERRIES, APPLES)

A plant antioxidant sometimes called "nature's Benadryl" for its ability to stabilize the cells that release histamine. Useful as a topper for allergy-prone dogs, in small amounts.

SOLUBLE FIBER (PUMPKIN, SWEET POTATO)

Already central to Section 2 of the main guide. Soluble fiber feeds beneficial gut bacteria, which in turn produce compounds that reduce gut inflammation directly — this is why pumpkin appears in nearly every sensitive-stomach recipe.

TURMERIC & GINGER, IN FOOD AMOUNTS

Both contain compounds with mild anti-inflammatory activity. Used here strictly as a food ingredient in small pinches — not as a therapeutic supplement dose, which should only be set by your veterinarian.

2.3 Anti-inflammatory toppers

The Substitution Matrix in the main guide mentions duck, rabbit, and venison only as protein swaps — they never appear in a full recipe. Here they get one: as small "toppers," spooned over any base recipe from Sections 1 or 2, giving you a novel-protein rotation option without cooking a second full meal.

⚠ HOW TO USE A TOPPER

Toppers are not a full meal — they supplement roughly 15–20% of the bowl on top of a base recipe. If you're mid-elimination-trial (Chapter 1), do not add a topper with a protein your dog hasn't had before; it defeats the trial.

TOPPER 1 — NOVEL PROTEIN

Duck & Blueberry Quercetin Topper

Novel protein + antioxidant boost for skin-cluster dogs



PREP TIME

15 min



DIFFICULTY

Easy



BEST FOR

Skin / Allergy

INGREDIENTS

- 100g duck breast, boiled, no skin
- 1 tsp fish oil
- 2 tbsp blueberries, mashed
- Pinch of ground ginger (optional)

- 1** Boil duck breast thoroughly, no seasoning. Shred or dice finely.
- 2** Mash blueberries into a rough paste — this releases more quercetin than whole berries.
- 3** Combine duck, blueberry, fish oil, and optional ginger. Cool before serving.

Pair with: Recipe 1 (Whitefish & Rice) or Recipe 3 (Hydrolyzed Protein Formula) from the main guide — spoon 2-3 tbsp on top per meal.

TOPPER 2 — NOVEL PROTEIN

Rabbit & Pumpkin Gut-Soothing Topper

Novel protein + soluble fiber for digestive-cluster dogs



PREP TIME

20 min



DIFFICULTY

Easy



BEST FOR

Sensitive Stomach

INGREDIENTS

- 100g rabbit meat, boiled
- 1 tsp coconut oil
- 3 tbsp plain pumpkin puree

- 1** Boil rabbit meat until fully cooked, no seasoning. Shred finely.
- 2** Mix with plain pumpkin puree and coconut oil until smooth.
- 3** Serve at room temperature, cooled completely.

Pair with: Recipe 4 (Gentle Chicken & Rice) or Recipe 6 (Pumpkin Gut-Healing Bowl) — spoon 2-3 tbsp on top per meal.

TOPPER 3 — NOVEL PROTEIN

Venison & Turmeric Recovery Topper

For dogs who've reacted to multiple common proteins



PREP TIME
20 min



DIFFICULTY
Easy



BEST FOR
**Multi-protein
sensitivity**

INGREDIENTS

- 100g venison, boiled
- Pinch of ground turmeric
- 1 tsp fish oil
- 1 tbsp plain pumpkin puree

- 1** Boil venison thoroughly, no seasoning. Shred or dice finely.
- 2** Combine with turmeric, fish oil, and pumpkin puree.
- 3** Serve cooled. Introduce gradually — venison is rich; start with a smaller spoonful.

Note: venison is a truly novel protein for most dogs — ideal if chicken, turkey, and fish have all been ruled out. Confirm with your vet before using during an active elimination trial.



CHAPTER THREE

The Safe Weight-Loss Protocol

Turning the weight-management recipes into an actual plan — without losing muscle along with fat.

- Why crash diets backfire on dogs
- The 9-point Body Condition Score
- A phased reduction schedule
- Warning signs of over-restriction

CHAPTER 03

3.1 Why crash diets backfire

Section 3 of the main guide gives you four excellent low-calorie recipes. What it doesn't give you is a schedule — and cutting calories too fast is one of the most common mistakes in canine weight management.

⚠ THE CORE PROBLEM WITH CUTTING TOO FAST

When calories drop too sharply, the body doesn't just burn fat — it starts breaking down **muscle** for energy too. The scale shows progress, but the dog ends up lighter *and* weaker, with a slower metabolism that makes the next round of weight loss even harder.

The fix isn't a different recipe — it's a **gradual, monitored reduction** that keeps protein intake high (all four Section 3 recipes lead with a lean protein for exactly this reason) while calories come down slowly enough for fat loss to outpace muscle loss.

3.2 The Body Condition Score (BCS)

The scale tells you total weight. The Body Condition Score tells you whether that weight is fat, muscle, or both — and it's what your vet uses to set a real target instead of an arbitrary number.

SCORE	WHAT YOU FEEL & SEE
1-3 — Too thin	Ribs, spine, hip bones visible with no fat cover. Not the goal of this protocol.
4-5 — Ideal	Ribs easily felt under a thin fat layer. Visible waist from above. This is the target.
6-7 — Overweight	Ribs felt only with firm pressure. Waist barely visible or absent.
8-9 — Obese	Ribs not felt under heavy fat. No waist. Fat deposits on chest and base of tail.



HOW TO USE IT

Score your dog every 2 weeks by sight and touch (not just the scale). The goal is a slow, steady move of **one point per 4-8 weeks** — anything faster increases the muscle-loss risk from 3.1.

3.3 A phased reduction schedule

Apply this on top of whichever Section 3 recipe you're using — it tells you *how* to adjust the portion over time, not what to cook.

1
WEEKS

Weeks 1-2 — Baseline

Feed the Section 3 recipe at the portion guide amount for current weight. Record starting BCS and weight.

2
WEEKS

Weeks 3-4 — First check

Re-weigh and re-score BCS. No change yet is normal. Any rapid drop (over 2% of body weight per week) means portions are too low — increase slightly.

3
WEEKS

Weeks 5-8 — Adjust by 10%

If weight loss is under 1% per week, reduce the daily portion by roughly 10%. Never drop more than 10% at a time.

4
ONGOING

Continue until BCS 4-5

Keep repeating the 4-week check-and-adjust cycle. Once BCS 4-5 is reached, transition to a maintenance portion (usually 10-15% above the weight-loss amount).

3.4 Signs the restriction is too aggressive

Dull or thinning coat · Noticeable muscle loss over the shoulders or hindquarters (not just fat) · Constant begging or scavenging behavior · Lethargy beyond the first adjustment week · Weight loss faster than 2% of body weight per week

Any of these means it's time to increase the portion, not push through. A slower, sustained loss that preserves muscle is always the better outcome than a fast drop that has to be reversed.



Next: a deeper look at exactly what to keep out of the bowl — and what to use instead.



CHAPTER FOUR

Hidden Culprits & Functional Swaps

Beyond the acute-toxic list — the everyday ingredients quietly working against a sensitive dog's recovery.

- Hidden allergens most tutors miss
- Why each one is a problem
- Functional substitute for each

CHAPTER 04

4.1 Beyond the acute-danger list

Onion, garlic, grapes, chocolate, and avocado are acutely toxic — those are covered elsewhere and every tutor should already know them. This chapter is about a different, quieter category: ingredients that aren't emergencies, but that **actively work against** a dog recovering from skin or gut inflammation. They show up constantly in commercial treats, table scraps, and even some "natural" products.

WHY THESE MATTER MORE FOR THERAPEUTIC DIETS

A healthy dog might tolerate small amounts of these without visible issue. A dog actively healing from an inflamed gut or skin barrier has far less tolerance — even a trace amount can undo weeks of progress on an elimination trial.

4.2

Hidden culprits, why, and what to use instead

INGREDIENT	WHY IT'S A PROBLEM	USE INSTEAD
Dairy	Most adult dogs are lactose-intolerant; a common hidden trigger for loose stool.	Small amounts of plain, unsweetened goat yogurt if tolerated — or skip entirely
Wheat / Gluten	One of the most common true protein allergens in dogs, alongside dairy and beef.	White rice, quinoa, oats (Recipes 1, 2, 4)
Soy	A frequent hidden allergen in commercial treats and fillers; cross-reacts in some dogs sensitized to other legumes.	Lean animal protein instead of soy-based fillers
Corn (as filler)	Rarely a true allergen, but a common low-quality filler that adds little nutritional value to a healing diet.	Sweet potato, pumpkin (already central to Section 2)

INGREDIENT	WHY IT'S A PROBLEM	USE INSTEAD
Artificial dyes/flavors	Common in commercial treats; linked anecdotally to skin flare-ups in sensitive dogs, though evidence is mixed.	Homemade toppers from Chapter 2, or single-ingredient dried meat treats
Preservatives (BHA/BHT, ethoxyquin)	Found in lower-quality commercial kibble; some tutors see symptom improvement after switching brands even without a full homemade switch.	Fresh-cooked meals (this guide) or kibble preserved with mixed tocopherols (vitamin E) — see Bonus C
Fried / high-fat table scraps	High fat load is inflammatory and a common trigger for pancreatitis flare-ups in dogs already prone to digestive upset.	Fish oil in controlled, small amounts (already dosed in the main recipes)
"Meat by-products" (generic)	An umbrella term that can include inconsistent protein sources — a problem specifically for elimination trials, where the exact protein must be known.	Named, single proteins only — chicken breast, turkey, whitefish, duck, rabbit, venison

⚠️ THE ELIMINATION-TRIAL RULE

During an active trial (Chapter 1), **any** ingredient with an unclear or generic source — "natural flavor," "meat by-product," "animal fat" — can invalidate the whole 8 weeks. If you can't name the exact protein, don't feed it during a trial.

4.3 Putting it together

None of this replaces the Substitution Matrix in the main guide — it works alongside it. Use the Matrix to rotate proteins and vegetables for variety; use this chapter to audit anything *outside* the 10 recipes before it goes in the bowl — treats, chews, table scraps, or a kibble you're still feeding alongside the homemade meals.



Next: three practical tools — knowing when to call the vet, tracking symptoms, and reading any label with confidence.



BONUS TOOL A

Red Flags: When to Call the Vet

Diet helps. It doesn't fix everything. Here's where the line is.

A.1 Emergency — stop and call now

Vomiting or diarrhea with blood · Repeated vomiting (more than 3x in a day) · Visible difficulty breathing · Sudden swelling of the face or throat · Collapse or extreme lethargy · Suspected ingestion of a toxic food

None of these are a "wait and see with the diet" situation, even if you're mid-elimination-trial. Stop, and go straight to your vet or nearest emergency clinic.

A.2 See your vet this week — not an emergency, but not "just diet" either

- ✓ No improvement at all after 3 full weeks of a strict elimination trial
- ✓ Symptoms that worsen despite the diet change
- ✓ Weight loss faster than 2% of body weight per week (Chapter 3)
- ✓ New symptoms appearing that weren't there before (limping, excessive thirst, changes in urination)
- ✓ Skin infections that look infected — pus, spreading redness, heat, odor

WHY THIS LIST EXISTS

Therapeutic diets are powerful, but they treat food-related triggers specifically. Symptoms that don't fit that pattern, or that escalate instead of improve, are your cue that something else may be going on — and every week spent troubleshooting alone is a week that condition goes untreated.



BONUS TOOL B

The Printable Symptom Diary

The single biggest factor in a successful elimination trial:
consistent tracking, not memory.

PRINTABLE TOOL

Weekly Symptom Diary

Print one page per week during any elimination trial (Chapter 1) or weight-loss protocol (Chapter 3). Fill in daily — it only takes a minute.

DAY	FOOD GIVEN	STOOL	SKIN/ITCH (1-5)	ENERGY	NOTES
Mon					
Tue					
Wed					
Thu					
Fri					
Sat					
Sun					

HOW TO SCORE "SKIN/ITCH"

1 = no visible itching · 2 = occasional scratching · 3 = regular scratching, no damage · 4 = visible redness or hot spots · 5 = open sores or bleeding from scratching. Write the number, not a description — numbers are what let you spot a real trend.

WEEKLY SUMMARY

Weight this week: _____ kg BCS: _____ (1-9)

Overall trend vs. last week: ☐ Better ☐ Same ☐ Worse

B.1 Why this matters more than it seems

Most tutors abandon an elimination trial around week 3 or 4 — not because it isn't working, but because without written tracking, day-to-day fluctuation feels like failure. A dog can have one itchy day out of an overall improving week, and without a log, that one bad day is what gets remembered.

Bring this diary (or a photo of each week's page) to your vet visit. It turns "he still seems itchy sometimes" into an actual trend line your vet can act on.



Last tool: making sense of any bag of food you're still feeding alongside these recipes.

C



BONUS TOOL C

How to Read a Dog Food Label

For the days you're not cooking — knowing what's actually in the bag.

c.1 The ingredient list is ordered by weight

Ingredients are legally listed heaviest-first, *before cooking* — which is the trick behind a common labeling loophole.

THE "FRESH MEAT FIRST" TRICK

"Chicken" listed first sounds ideal, but fresh chicken is roughly 70% water. Once cooked, that water is gone — and a food might actually be mostly corn or wheat by finished weight, even with meat listed first. Look for a named meat *meal* ("chicken meal") near the top too — meal is already dehydrated, so its listed weight reflects actual protein content more honestly.

c.2 Red-flag terms to scan for

- ⚠️ **"Meat by-product" or "animal fat"** (generic, unnamed source — see Chapter 4.2)
- ⚠️ **"Animal digest"** — a flavor coating of unspecified origin
- ⚠️ **Artificial colors** (Red 40, Yellow 5/6) — dogs don't see these colors; they're for the owner
- ⚠️ **BHA, BHT, ethoxyquin** — older-generation preservatives (Chapter 4.3)

c.3 The Guaranteed Analysis panel

This panel gives you crude protein, fat, fiber, and moisture as percentages — useful for a quick sanity check against what you already know from this guide.

LOOK FOR	WHY
Protein ≥ 25% (dry matter)	Supports the muscle-preservation goal from Chapter 3
Named single protein source	Required for any elimination-trial-safe product (Chapter 4.4)
Fiber source you recognize	Pumpkin, beet pulp, or similar — not just "fiber" unnamed

THE SIMPLEST RULE OF ALL

If you can't pronounce most of the ingredient list, or can't tell your vet exactly what protein your dog is eating, it's not a safe choice during an elimination trial — regardless of what the front of the bag claims.

CLOSING

You Now Have the Full Picture

The main guide gave you 10 recipes and a substitution matrix. This companion gave you the part that decides whether they work: confirming the real cause, understanding the science, protecting muscle during weight loss, and auditing every hidden ingredient standing in the way.

Keep this book next to *Therapeutic Diets for Dogs* — not as a replacement, but as the missing half. Revisit Chapter 1 any time a new symptom shows up, and the Symptom Diary every time you start a new elimination trial.



*Healing takes weeks, not days. You now have every
tool to make those weeks count.*



Beyond the Recipes

A Companion Guide to Therapeutic Diets for Dogs